I Analyzed My Spotify Data So You'd Think About Yours

Written, coded, and overanalyzed by Nadia Bourne

I am an extremely average consumer.

I am an extremely average consumer...

...but is that really my fault?

What I built this with:

From this class:

- R & RStudio
- tidyverse
- Plotly
- Regex

On my own:

- Shiny
- A little CSS

Inspirations:

The Pudding (a site that makes visual essays out of data) inspired my style and format. *Data Feminism* introduced me to the concepts I wrote about, specifically:

- Data are never raw (chapter 2)
- Data are never neutral (chapter 6)
- Key principles of accessibility and accountability

I investigated two suspects:

Spotify... and me.

#1: Spotify, the platform

Wrapped counts **plays**, and streaming rewards shorter songs, because a short song racks up plays faster. And I find most of my music through **Spotify's own features**, so the platform shaped my listening before I ever picked a song.

Both of these points are in the essay with evidence.

#2: Me, the narrator & designer

I cleaned the data. I made the visualizations. Along the way, I made decisions, and those decisions shaped the story.

We’re going to play a game: I’m about to show you a graph to try to convince you I’m an average consumer. **I’m going to try to trick you without lying.** Your job is to catch me.

Some tricks I pulled:

- I defined ‘Pop Related Subgenre’ myself
- Similar colors were used for ‘Pop’ and ‘Pop Related Subgenre’ to conflate the two visually
- ‘Top 11 artists’ was decided by number of tracks in Top 100, not Spotify’s list of top artists
- Only chose top 11 because artists 12-15 weren’t pop-related

But the biggest one is…

I broadly labeled each artist by one singular genre, yet the graphic itself counts number of songs. An artist’s songs aren’t necessarily the same genre, or even Pop at all.

So, the verdict. Is it my fault?

Partially, no.

Spotify shaped the pool: the songs that exist, the lengths they run, the artists their algorithm surfaces.

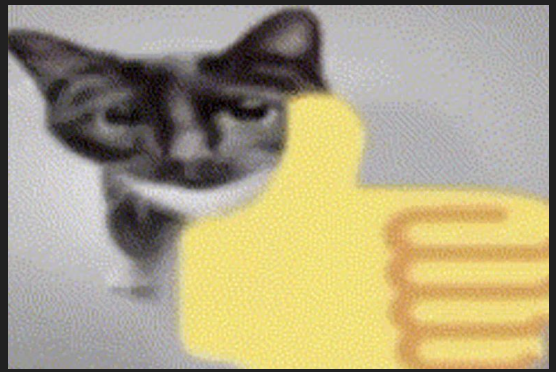
But also… partially, yes.

I chose the metrics, assigned the categories, & picked the colors. I decided what ‘average’ looked like before I ever showed it to you.

The platform influenced my listening.

But I influenced what you saw.

THANK YOU FOR LISTENING!



& don’t forget to THINK CRITICALLY ABOUT YOUR DATA! (link to repo for those who want it)